- Non-interference in the internal affairs of one another.
- Settlement of differences or disputes in a peaceful manner.
- Renunciation of the threat or use of force.
- Effective cooperation among themselves.

Structures and Mechanisms

The highest decision-making organ of ASEAN is the meeting of the ASEAN Heads of States and Governments. The ASEAN Summit is convened every year. The ASEAN Ministerial Meeting (Foreign Ministers) is held annually. The other structures include: the ASEAN Economic Ministers' Meeting, the ASEAN Finance Ministers' Meeting, and the Sectoral Ministers' meeting. There is also the Joint Ministerial Meeting (JMM). ASEAN also has a Secretariat and a Secretary-General.

Ministerial meetings are held regularly in different sectors such as agriculture and forestry, economics (trade), energy, environment, finance, health, information, investment, labour, law, regional haze and youth. Supporting these ministerial bodies are committees of senior officials, technical working groups and task forces.

To support the conduct of ASEAN's external relations, it has established committees composed of heads of diplomatic missions in different cities: Beijing, Brussels, Geneva, Islamabad, London, Moscow, New Delhi, New York, and Washington DC among others.

The Secretary-General of ASEAN is appointed on merit and accorded ministerial status. He has a five-year term; and he is mandated to initiate, advise, coordinate and implement ASEAN activities. The members of the professional staff of the ASEAN Secretariat are appointed on the principle of open recruitment and region-wide competition.

The ASEAN has also several specialized bodies and arrangements, promoting inter-governmental cooperation through various fora such as the:

- ASEAN Agricultural Development Planning Centre
- ASEAN-EC Management Centre